

Consider theoretical perspectives:

- **Stuart Hall's theory of representation** – the images of domesticity (including the two women hanging out the laundry) form part of the “shared conceptual road map” that give meaning to the “world” of the advert. Despite its comic strip visual construction, the scenario **represented** is familiar to the **audience** as a representation of their own lives.
- **David Gauntlett's theory of identity** – women represented in the advert act as **role models** of domestic perfection that the audience may want to construct their own sense of identity against.

A level only:

- **Liesbet Van Zoonen's feminist theory** – while their role socially and politically may have changed in the proceeding war years, the advert perhaps contradicts **Van Zoonen's** theory that the media contribute to social change by representing women in non-traditional roles and using non-sexist language.
- **bell hooks' feminist theory** argues that lighter skinned women are considered more desirable and fit better into the western ideology of beauty, and the advert could be seen to reinforce this by only representing “modern”, white women. This could also be linked to **Gilroy's ethnicity and post-colonial theories** that media texts reinforce colonial power. Contextually, this power has perhaps been challenged at this moment in American history by the events of WWII.

PART 3: STARTING POINTS – Audiences

Social context:

Despite women having seen their roles in society change during the War (where they were needed in medical, military support and other roles outside of the home) domestic products of the 1950s continued to be aimed at female audiences.

The likely **target audience** of increasingly affluent lower-middle class women were, at this point in the 1950s, being appealed to because of their supposed need for innovative domestic technologies and products. The increasing popularity during the 1950s of supermarkets stocking a wider range of products led to an increased focus by corporations on brands and their **unique selling points**.

Consider how industries target audiences, and how audiences interpret and use the media:

- The likely **audience demographic** is constructed through the advert's use of women with whom they might **personally identify (Uses and Gratifications Theory)**. These young women are likely to be newly married and with young families (clothing belonging to men and children on the washing line creates these **connotations**).
- The endorsement from *Good Housekeeping Magazine* makes them an **Opinion Leader** for the **target audience**, reinforcing the repeated assertion that *Tide* is the market-leading product.
- The **preferred reading (Stuart Hall)** of the advert's reassuring **lexical fields** (“trust”, “truly safe”, “miracle”, “nothing like”) is that, despite being a “new” product, *Tide* provides solutions to the audience's domestic chores needs.

Consider theoretical perspectives:

Reception theory – Stuart Hall

- The **indirect mode of address** made by the woman in the main image **connotes** that her relationship with the product is of prime importance (*Tide* has what she wants). This, according to **Hall**, is the dominant or **hegemonic encoding** of the advert's primary message that should be received by “you women.”
- The **direct mode of address** of the images in the top right and bottom left-hand corner link to the **imperative** “Remember!” and the use of **personal pronouns** (“your wash”, “you can buy”).

Cultivation theory – George Gerbner

- Advertising developed significantly during the 1950s and this theory, developed by **Gerbner** in the early 1970s, explains some of the ways in which audiences may be influenced by media texts such as adverts.
- The *Tide* advert aims to **cultivate** the ideas that: this is the brand leader; nothing else washes to the same standard as *Tide*; it's a desirable product for its female audience; and its “miracle suds” are an innovation for the domestic washing market. **Gerbner's** theory would argue that the repetition of these key messages causes **audiences** to increasingly align their own **ideologies** with them (in this case positively, creating a product that “goes into more American homes than any other washday product”).